

BRIDGING THE DIVIDE

By doubting the historicity of Ram, the UPA had delivered the BJP a ready-made formula for revival. The party instead revived the old leadership battle, forcing Vajpayee to play peacemaker.

■ By Priya Sahgal

The backdrop said it all. A huge calendar art motif of Lord Ram sported the call to all devotees to bridge the chasm of faith. On the face of it, the BJP National Executive was being held at a most opportune moment. The UPA regime had handed on a platter, an emotive issue that could have brought all Ram bhakts together to take on the enemy. By declaring that it doubted the existence of Ram, UPA had provided a ready-made Ravana to BJP.

It was a god-given opportunity for the self-proclaimed keepers of the faith to blow the conch and set the tone of the party campaign for the mid-term polls expected early next year. But instead of scripting out the expected Ramayan, BJP seemed to have mixed its scriptures and launched into a full fledged Mahabharat. The dominant question at the executive was not which issues BJP would raise against the Congress, but rather, who would lead the party. Eventually, it took a long-distance missive from the party patriarch to declare ceasefire and lay a sethu to bridge the feuding factions. Atal Bihari Vajpayee had to yet again come to the rescue of the party, to restore faith among the faithful.

He may have not been present in Bhopal, but his presence was overwhelming. The meeting began amidst a whisper campaign by some of Rajnath Singh's GenNext rivals who claimed that there really was only one agenda at the executive: to declare Advani as the prime ministerial candidate. Perhaps in panic, Advani's *bete noire* Murli Manohar Joshi retorted that the leadership issue was anything but settled. Jaswant Singh added to the cacophony in his inimitable style: "Our leader is Advaniji. Atalji has been the supreme leader of our party. Advaniji has been the right hand of Atalji for over 50 years." It almost



LIGHTING THE LAMP OF PEACE:
Advani (left) with Rajnath

PANKAJ TIWARI